

BREAKING FREE FROM CODEPENDENCY

A Recovery Workbook

Learn to Love Yourself First

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WHAT IS CODEPENDENCY?

Codependency is a pattern of putting others' needs so far above your own that you lose yourself in the process.

CODEPENDENCY IS:

- Needing to be needed
- Feeling responsible for others' feelings
- Difficulty identifying your own needs
- Poor boundaries or no boundaries
- People-pleasing at the expense of yourself
- Staying in unhealthy relationships out of fear
- Controlling others 'for their own good'
- Confusing love with rescuing or fixing

CODEPENDENCY IS NOT:

- Being a caring person (healthy caring has limits)
- Being in a relationship (interdependence is healthy)
- A permanent identity (recovery is possible)

ROOT CAUSES:

- Growing up with addiction in the family
- Having emotionally unavailable parents
- Being parentified (caring for adults as a child)
- Trauma or neglect in childhood
- Learning that love = sacrifice

CODEPENDENCY SELF-ASSESSMENT

Rate each statement 1-5 (1=never, 5=always):

1. I feel responsible for other people's feelings ____
2. I have difficulty saying no to people ____
3. I put others' needs before my own regularly ____
4. I feel guilty when I do something for myself ____
5. I need approval from others to feel good ____
6. I stay in relationships that hurt me ____
7. I try to fix or control other people ____
8. I feel anxious when others are upset with me ____
9. I neglect my own needs to help others ____
10. I have trouble identifying what I want ____
11. I apologize even when it's not my fault ____
12. I attract people who need 'saving' ____
13. I fear being abandoned or alone ____
14. I feel empty without someone to care for ____
15. I minimize or deny my own problems ____
16. I cover for others' bad behavior ____
17. I struggle to make decisions alone ____
18. I ignore my own pain to focus on others ____
19. I define myself by my relationships ____
20. I have difficulty accepting compliments ____

TOTAL: ____/100

20-40: Mild tendencies 41-60: Moderate 61-80: Significant 81+: Severe

PEOPLE-PLEASING PATTERNS

People-pleasing feels like kindness but it's actually self-abandonment.

MY PEOPLE-PLEASING BEHAVIORS:

- ___ Saying yes when I mean no
- ___ Doing things I don't want to do to avoid conflict
- ___ Agreeing with opinions I don't actually hold
- ___ Over-volunteering at work/church/school
- ___ Apologizing for things that aren't my fault
- ___ Suppressing my true feelings to keep peace
- ___ Doing favors and then feeling resentful
- ___ Changing my personality depending on who I'm with

WHO DO I PEOPLE-PLEASE THE MOST?

Person: _____ Why: _____

Person: _____ Why: _____

WHAT PEOPLE-PLEASING COSTS ME:

Energy: _____

Authenticity: _____

Self-respect: _____

Time: _____

THE TRUTH: People who only love the 'pleasing' version of you don't actually love YOU.

BOUNDARY IDENTIFICATION WORKSHEET

Boundaries are not walls. They are doors YOU control.

TYPES OF BOUNDARIES:

Physical: Personal space, touch, privacy

Emotional: Not taking on others' feelings as your own

Time: How much time you give to others vs yourself

Material: Money, possessions, lending/giving

Mental: Your right to your own opinions and thoughts

WHERE I NEED STRONGER BOUNDARIES:

With my partner/spouse:

I allow _____ that I need to stop allowing.

With my family:

I allow _____ that I need to stop allowing.

At work:

I allow _____ that I need to stop allowing.

With friends:

I allow _____ that I need to stop allowing.

BOUNDARY I WILL SET THIS WEEK:

What: _____

With whom: _____

How I'll communicate it: _____

SAYING NO - 10 SCRIPTS

Saying no is a complete sentence. But here are softer options:

1. 'I appreciate you asking, but I can't commit to that.'
2. 'That doesn't work for me, but thank you.'
3. 'I need to check my schedule and get back to you.'
(Buys time when you freeze in the moment)
4. 'I'm not available for that, but I hope it goes well.'
5. 'I've already committed my time elsewhere.'
6. 'I'm prioritizing my own needs right now.'
7. 'No.' (That's it. No explanation needed.)
8. 'I care about you AND my answer is no.'
9. 'Let me think about what I can realistically offer.'
10. 'I've learned that overcommitting hurts us both.'

PRACTICE: Write 'No' to a current request in your life:

Request: _____

My response: _____

DETACHMENT EXERCISES

Detachment means releasing what you cannot control - with LOVE.

EXERCISE 1: The Responsibility Check

Situation I'm stressed about: _____

Is this MY responsibility? YES / NO

Can I actually control this? YES / NO

If NO: What can I release? _____

EXERCISE 2: The Loving Release

'I love [person] AND I release the outcome.'

'I cannot want recovery more than they do.'

'Their choices are theirs. My peace is mine.'

EXERCISE 3: The STOP Technique

S - Stop what you are doing

T - Take a breath

O - Observe (is this mine to fix?)

P - Proceed (with YOUR life, not theirs)

WHAT I AM CHOOSING TO DETACH FROM:

WHAT I AM CHOOSING TO FOCUS ON INSTEAD:

Detachment is not abandonment. It is self-preservation.

HEALTHY vs UNHEALTHY RELATIONSHIPS

HEALTHY (Interdependent) | UNHEALTHY (Codependent)

-----+-----

Both have separate identities | One loses self in the other

Both can say no | One always gives in

Feelings are shared openly | Feelings are hidden/managed

Both have outside friends | Isolation from others

Conflict = growth | Conflict = catastrophe

Both take responsibility | One always blamed

Space is respected | Clinginess or control

Love feels peaceful | Love feels chaotic

MY CURRENT RELATIONSHIPS:

Relationship 1: _____ Healthy / Unhealthy / Mixed

What needs to change: _____

Relationship 2: _____ Healthy / Unhealthy / Mixed

What needs to change: _____

SELF-WORTH AFFIRMATIONS:

- I am worthy of love WITHOUT earning it.
- I can be loved AND have boundaries.
- My needs are not too much.
- I am allowed to put myself first.
- I am whole on my own.

MY NEEDS MATTER + I-STATEMENTS

IDENTIFYING MY NEEDS (check what you've been neglecting):

- ☐ Rest and sleep ☐ Fun and play
☐ Alone time ☐ Physical touch
☐ Creative expression ☐ Financial security
☐ Honest communication ☐ Feeling heard
☐ Respect ☐ Freedom to choose

My most neglected need: _____

One action to meet this need today: _____

COMMUNICATION WITH I-STATEMENTS:

Instead of: 'You never listen to me!'

Try: 'I feel unheard when I'm interrupted.'

Formula: 'I feel [emotion] when [specific behavior]
because [impact]. I need [specific request].'

PRACTICE:

I feel _____ when you _____
because _____.
I need _____.

I feel _____ when you _____
because _____.
I need _____.

LETTING GO & BUILDING SELF-IDENTITY

LETTING GO EXERCISES:

Things I need to let go of:

- The belief that I can fix other people: _____
- The need for everyone to like me: _____
- Responsibility for others' emotions: _____
- Guilt for having my own needs: _____

BUILDING MY IDENTITY (separate from others):

Outside of my relationships, I am:

Things I enjoy doing ALONE:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Opinions I hold that are MINE (not borrowed):

Goals that are mine alone (not for someone else):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I am learning to be complete within myself.

WEEKLY BOUNDARY PRACTICE LOG - WEEK 1

Day 1:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 2:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 3:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 4:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 5:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 6:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 7:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

WEEKLY BOUNDARY PRACTICE LOG - WEEK 2

Day 1:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 2:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 3:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 4:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 5:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 6:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 7:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

WEEKLY BOUNDARY PRACTICE LOG - WEEK 3

Day 1:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 2:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 3:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 4:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 5:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 6:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 7:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

WEEKLY BOUNDARY PRACTICE LOG - WEEK 4

Day 1:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 2:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 3:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 4:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 5:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 6:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

Day 7:

Boundary set or maintained: _____

Said NO to: _____

Self-care action: _____ Guilt level (1-10): _____

MY RECOVERY COMMITMENTS

I commit to my codependency recovery:

1. I will identify and honor my own needs daily.
2. I will practice saying no without guilt.
3. I will not take responsibility for others' feelings.
4. I will maintain boundaries even when uncomfortable.
5. I will not try to fix, control, or rescue others.
6. I will build an identity separate from my relationships.
7. I will seek support (therapy, CoDA meetings, friends).
8. I will be patient and compassionate with myself.
9. I will celebrate small victories.
10. I choose ME without apology.

Signed: _____

Date: _____

RESOURCES:

- CoDA (Codependents Anonymous): www.coda.org
- Al-Anon (if loved one has addiction): www.al-anon.org
- Melody Beattie: 'Codependent No More'
- Therapy: Look for therapists specializing in codependency

You are worthy of the love you keep giving away to others.